AUWA Brand Guidelines

Created: April 2026. The working brand reference for all AUWA touchpoints. Load when working on visual design, social content, brand decisions, or any new touchpoint.

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1. Brand Essence

AUWA (あうわ) — "the harmony between the unseen and the seen." Kokoro (心) is the holistic Japanese concept that holds heart, mind, soul, and spirit as one undivided whole. The brand makes the invisible visible: invisible emotions (app), invisible craftsmanship (store), invisible kokoro within all living things (stories).

The brand feels like: a quiet room in a Japanese temple at dusk. Dark, warm, still. Then light enters.

Brand reference points:

- **Aesop** — Luxury minimalism, craft-forward. Dark interiors, serif type, every store feels like the same calm room. The gold standard for "premium through restraint." AUWA's app and social should feel like walking into an Aesop store: you immediately know someone cared about every detail.
- **Kinfolk** — Editorial calm, intentional living. Wide-tracked serif wordmark. Generous white space. Photography that breathes. The confidence to leave half the page empty. AUWA's typography and spacing should carry this same unhurried authority.
- **Cereal** — Refined design magazine. Restrained colour palette, serif headlines, atmospheric travel photography. The exact intersection of design culture and wanderlust that AUWA's audience inhabits.
- **Hoshinoya** — Japanese luxury hospitality. Dark, warm, nature-integrated. Space as design. Shows how Japanese premium doesn't need to be austere — it can be warm and inviting while remaining minimal. AUWA's dark palette should feel this way: enveloping, not cold.
- **Studio Ghibli** — Warmth beneath simplicity. Hand-drawn worlds that adults take as seriously as children. The precedent for illustrated content that bypasses cynicism. AUWA's illustration integration follows this path.

- **Aman Resorts** — "Less is more" luxury. No logos on the building. The brand exists in the experience, not the signage. AUWA should feel like this: the brand recedes, the experience comes forward.
- **Monocle** — Tyler Brûlé's editorial worldview extended into products, retail, and radio. One coherent taste level across every touchpoint. Serif masthead, clean layouts. Proves that editorial authority translates into commerce.
- **Mubi** — Film streaming platform with a dark, cinematic UI. Serif display type over moody imagery. Proves that dark interfaces with serif typography can feel premium and inviting for a digital product.

What AUWA is not: Headspace-style illustration pop. Wellness-brand pastels. Busy Japanese maximalism. Tech-startup energy. Anything with a gradient that screams "app."

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2. Logo

The Wordmark

The AUWA logo is the wordmark itself — the letters A-U-W-A set in EB Garamond with wide tracking. No separate symbol, no icon, no monogram. The word is the logo.

The wordmark works because:

- The natural symmetry of A-U-W-A mirrors itself (the two A's as bookends, U-W as the centre)
- This symmetry echoes the etymology: あ (heavens) and わ (earth) framing う (connection)
- Serif letterforms carry signals of craft, history, and intention — the right signals for a Japanese philosophy brand
- It scales cleanly from social profile to website header to printed materials

Wordmark specifications:

- **Typeface:** EB Garamond (currently rendered as SVG on the website)
- **Case:** All uppercase
- **Letter-spacing:** 0.25em
- **Colour:** void (oklch 0.08 0.025 250) on light backgrounds; white (inverted) on dark backgrounds
- **Size:** 16px height on mobile, 21px on desktop (website header)

Minimum clear space: The height of the letter "U" on all sides.

Usage:

- The wordmark appears in the header across all sections of auwa.life
- Always set in EB Garamond, never redrawn or substituted
- Never placed over busy imagery — always over solid dark or solid light backgrounds
- Never distorted, outlined, shadowed, or animated (the orb animates; the wordmark is still)

Social Profile Image

The wordmark at social icon scale (110x110px display). Two options to test:

Option A: The full "AUWA" wordmark centred in a dark circle (void background). Works if the tracking is tight enough to read at small sizes.

Option B: A single "A" in Cormorant Light, centred in a dark circle. Cleaner at icon scale, still recognisably the brand.

Test both at actual Instagram/LinkedIn display sizes before deciding. The character is never the profile image — it lives inside the experience, not on the business layer.

What About a Custom Logo Later?

If the brand grows to the point where a bespoke mark would add value (physical packaging, figure authentication stamps, embossed on store products), explore a custom-drawn version of the wordmark — refined letterforms with subtle ligatures or a harmonised U-W connection. This is a Year 2 investment, not a launch requirement. The Cormorant wordmark is strong enough to launch with.

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3. Typography

The Decision: EB Garamond (Locked)

EB Garamond was chosen as AUWA's primary serif after testing against Cormorant, Playfair Display, and DM Serif Display. It carries real historical weight (based on Claude Garamond's original 16th-century designs), reads beautifully at both display and body sizes, and has the

scholarly, deep character that suits a philosophy-forward brand. More readable than Cormorant at body sizes, more refined than Playfair at display sizes.

Available via Google Fonts, loaded through `next/font` with `display: swap`. Weights: 400, 500, 600, 700. Styles: normal, italic.

Future consideration: If the brand reaches the point where a premium foundry font adds value (physical print, packaging), Canela (Commercial Type) or Tiempos (Klim) would be the natural upgrades — they're the typefaces AUWA's reference brands actually use. Year 2 investment at earliest.

Primary Serif: EB Garamond (Display + Editorial)

The voice of AUWA. Used for all brand-level, emotional, and editorial text. Registered as `--font-display` / `font-display` in Tailwind.

- **Regular/400:** Headlines, subheadlines, brand copy, article body, about page prose, pullquotes — the default weight for everything
- **Medium/500:** Occasional emphasis (sparingly)
- **SemiBold/600:** Available but rarely used
- **Bold/700:** Available for special emphasis; not currently used on the website
- **Italic:** Available for editorial emphasis and book cover text

Secondary: Instrument Sans (Functional Sans-Serif)

The working typeface. Used for all UI and functional elements. This stays regardless of serif choice.

- **Regular (400):** Body text, navigation, form labels, metadata, captions
- **Medium (500):** Buttons, small caps navigation (as in teaser header)
- **SemiBold (600):** Strong emphasis where needed (sparingly)

Clean, modern, slightly warm. Doesn't compete with the serif — it disappears into the background, letting the serif do the emotional work.

Japanese: Noto Sans JP

For Japanese text (micro-season names, kanji, Rieko's Japanese copy). Light (300) and Regular (400) weights only. Consider also testing **Noto Serif JP** for editorial Japanese text (paired with whichever Latin serif you choose).

Type Hierarchy (Implemented — auwa.life)

The website uses a clean sizing system: 12px for metadata labels, 13px for interactive uppercase elements, 14px for all UI text, 18-19px for article body, and responsive clamp() for display sizes.

Element	Typeface	Weight	Size	Tracking
Wordmark / Logo	EB Garamond (SVG)	—	16px mobile / 21px desktop	—
Page title (h1)	EB Garamond	400	clamp(2.5rem, 5.5vw, 4.5rem)	0.01em
Section heading (h2)	EB Garamond	400	28px / 32px	0.01em
Card title	EB Garamond	400	20px / 22px	0.01em
Article body	EB Garamond	400	18px / 19px	0.005em
Pullquote (in-article)	EB Garamond *italic*	400	clamp(1.75rem, 3.5vw, 2.75rem)	0.005em
Pullquote (hero-scale)	EB Garamond	400	clamp(2rem, 5.5vw, 4.5rem)	0.005em
Page subtitle	EB Garamond	400	clamp(1.1rem, 2vw, 1.4rem)	—
About page prose	EB Garamond	400	18px / 20px	—
Navigation	Instrument Sans	400	14px	0.06em
UI text / excerpts	Instrument Sans	400	14px	—
Form button (CTA)	Instrument Sans	500	14px	0.02em
Uppercase filter	Instrument Sans	400	13px	0.06em
Uppercase metadata	Instrument Sans	400	12px	0.08em
Kanji (micro-season)	Noto Serif JP	400	clamp(3rem, 8vw, 6.5rem)	0.06em
Image captions	Instrument Sans	400	13px	—
Footer copyright	Instrument Sans	400	14px	0.02em

4. Colour System

The Principle

AUWA lives in darkness. Light comes from within — from the kokoro being revealed. The brand's default state is dark and quiet. Colour enters through gradients, glows, and the Yamato emotional states. This mirrors the app experience: you arrive in darkness, and AUWA's light shower reveals your kokoro in colour.

Foundation Palette (Established in Teaser)

```
Void (background):        oklch(0.08  0.025  250)
Cosmic 900:               oklch(0.13  0.030  250)
Cosmic 800:               oklch(0.18  0.028  250)
Cosmic 700:               oklch(0.25  0.025  250)
Cosmic 600:               oklch(0.35  0.022  250)
Cosmic 500:               oklch(0.45  0.020  250)  — secondary text
Cosmic 400:               oklch(0.60  0.018  250)  — subtle text
Cosmic 300:               oklch(0.75  0.015  250)
Cosmic 200:               oklch(0.87  0.012  250)  — primary text
Cosmic 100:               oklch(0.93  0.008  250)
Cosmic 50:                oklch(0.97  0.005  250)  — bright text
Glow:                     oklch(0.85  0.15   105)  — orb, accents
Glow Dim:                 oklch(0.70  0.10   105)  — hover states
```

These are cool-toned, deep, slightly purple-blue darks. Not pure black — there's always a hint of cosmic depth.

Yamato Emotional State Colours (5 Gradient Families)

```
Hare (  /Radiant):     oklch(0.82  0.14  85)   — warm gold/amber
Takaburi (  /Intense):  oklch(0.60  0.18  25)   — deep crimson/rust
Aware (  /Reflective):  oklch(0.70  0.06  250)  — cool blue/indigo
Yuragi (  /Unsettled):  oklch(0.65  0.12  55)   — amber/ochre
Nagomi (  /Serene):      oklch(0.75  0.10  160)  — soft sage/green
```

These are the starting points for the 5 gradient families used in the app's kokoro revelation screens and across social content. Each emotional state has a 3-4 stop gradient to be developed in Figma:

- **Hare (Radiant):** Gold → amber → soft peach (warm, expanding, light)
- **Takaburi (Intense):** Crimson → burnt orange → dark rust (intense, rising, hot)
- **Aware (Reflective):** Indigo → steel blue → soft grey-blue (cool, receding, still)
- **Yuragi (Unsettled):** Amber → ochre → muted bronze (shifting, restless, warm-cool tension)
- **Nagomi (Serene):** Sage → warm olive → soft earth (grounded, open, calm)

Light Theme (Website — auwa.life)

The auwa.life website uses a light-mode, Kinfolk-inspired editorial aesthetic. The dark palette remains the brand's emotional core (used in the app, social content, and the newsletter module on the website), but the editorial site itself is light — maximising readability for long-form articles and letting photography breathe.

- **Page background:** Pure white — `oklch(1 0 0)` / `--color-surface`
- **Raised surfaces:** `oklch(0.95 0.005 250)` / `--color-surface-raised` — used for placeholder images, card backgrounds
- **Primary text:** void (`oklch(0.08 0.025 250)`) at various opacities (100% for headings, 80% for body prose, 60% for subtitles, 50% for excerpts, 40% for metadata labels)
- **Borders/dividers:** void at 8-20% opacity
- **Wordmark:** void on light backgrounds
- **Interactive hover:** void at 70% opacity (text darkens on hover from lighter state, or lightens from full opacity)

Dark Theme (App, Social, Newsletter Module)

The brand's natural state. Used for the Kokoro Mirror app, social content templates, and the "Letters from Japan" newsletter section on the website.

- **Background:** void (`oklch(0.08 0.025 250)`)
- **Primary text:** white at various opacities
- **Wordmark:** white (inverted)
- **Form borders:** white at 20% opacity, 50% on focus

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5. The Orb

The glowing orb is AUWA's presence before the character appears. It pulses gently, breathes, and transforms during the light shower. On the teaser page it sits at the centre of the screen as the primary visual element.

Usage:

- Teaser pages: hero element
- App: the input screen's visual anchor, transforms into the light shower
- Website backgrounds: very subtle, atmospheric (never dominant outside the app)
- Social: sparingly — the orb belongs to the digital experience, not print/static contexts

Never: place the orb next to the wordmark as a combined logo. They serve different purposes.

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6. Photography Direction

Tom's Japan photography catalogue (17M+ Unsplash views) is the primary photography asset. The style that works for AUWA:

What to use

- **Atmospheric landscapes:** Temples at dawn, misty mountains, bamboo groves, seasonal transitions. The images that got 8M+ views on Unsplash are exactly the right tone.
- **Quiet moments:** A path through trees, rain on stone, light through paper screens, a single flower. Ma (間) — space and silence.
- **Craftsmanship (for store):** Hands at work, close-ups of texture, the process of making. From the Monolise research trip photography.
- **Seasonal rhythm:** Cherry blossom, autumn maple, snow on stone, summer light. Content that refreshes with the 72 micro-seasons.

What to avoid

- Tourist-perspective shots (crowds, selfies, busy intersections)
- Overly saturated or HDR-processed images
- Food photography unless atmospheric (a bowl of matcha in morning light, yes; a plate of sushi with garnish detail, no)
- Anything that feels like a stock photo or travel blog

Treatment

- **Muted, slightly desaturated.** Bring warmth but pull back saturation. The palette should feel like it lives in the same world as the OKLCH cosmic colours.
- **Subtle grain/noise.** A light film grain texture (2-4% noise) prevents images feeling too digital and adds warmth. This is the bridge between Rieko's illustration dreaminess and the photographic content.
- **Gentle vignette.** Dark edges draw the eye inward and maintain the "light emerging from darkness" principle.
- **Consistent warmth.** All photography should lean warm — not orange, but the warmth of late afternoon light rather than clinical daylight.

Create a Lightroom preset that standardises this treatment so all photography content shares the same feel regardless of when or where it was shot.

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7. Illustration Integration

Rieko's illustrations are AUWA's most valuable asset. They need to coexist with photography and typography without the brand feeling like it has two visual languages fighting each other.

The Bridge

The bridge between photography and illustration is **colour and atmosphere.** Both should feel like they exist in the same world:

- Photography: muted, warm, slightly dreamy (grain, vignette, desaturation)
- Illustration: warm, textured, slightly muted (not full-saturation children's book colour)
- Both sit on the same dark backgrounds with the same cosmic colour system

Social Content Integration

When illustration and photography appear in the same feed, the unifying elements are:

- **Consistent dark background** (void or cosmic-900) framing every post
- **Consistent typography** (Cormorant for all quote/text overlays, same sizing and tracking)
- **Consistent colour temperature** (warm, never cold or clinical)

- **Consistent border/framing** (if using borders — same weight, same colour, same radius across all post types)

Post Types by Content

Content Type	Visual Source	Frame/Treatment
Kokoro Reveal	Illustration + type	Dark bg, character centred, Cormorant quote below/overlay, emotion gradient accent
Japanese Wisdom	Typography-led	Dark bg, Cormorant display text, subtle illustration or gradient accent element
Behind the Kokoro	Photography (process)	Dark bg frame, photo muted/warm, Instrument Sans caption
Seasonal Living	Photography (Japan)	Dark bg frame, photo muted/warm, optional Cormorant text overlay
The constant across all four pillars: **dark frame, warm content, Cormorant voice, space.**		

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8. Social Content Templates

The Grid Principle

The Instagram grid should feel like opening a book of quiet, beautiful pages — not a mosaic of competing styles. When someone visits @auwa.life and sees the 3x3 grid, every thumbnail should feel like it belongs in the same room.

This means:

- **Consistent aspect ratio:** 4:5 (1080x1350) for all feed posts (maximum screen real estate, consistent grid)
- **Consistent outer frame:** Every post sits on the void background with generous padding (minimum 60px equivalent on each side). The dark frame is the unifying element.

- **Consistent text placement:** All typography aligns to the same invisible grid within the frame
- **Colour restraint:** No more than one accent colour per post (from the emotion palette or glow)

Template 1: Quote Card (Kokoro Reveal / Japanese Wisdom)

- 1080 x 1350px, void background
- Cormorant Light centred text (28-36px for headline, 16-18px for attribution)
- Optional: subtle gradient wash behind text (one emotion colour at 10-15% opacity)
- Optional: small AUWA character illustration at bottom (thumbnail scale, atmospheric)
- Wordmark "AUWA" bottom-centre, small, cosmic-500

Template 2: Photography (Seasonal Living / Behind the Kokoro)

- 1080 x 1350px, void background with photo inset (leaving ~40-60px dark border on all sides)
- Photo treated: warm, desaturated, grain
- Optional: Cormorant text overlay (short, positioned lower third)
- Wordmark "AUWA" bottom-centre, small

Template 3: Illustration (Kokoro Reveal / Behind the Kokoro)

- 1080 x 1350px, void background
- Illustration centred or offset, breathing room around it
- Cormorant text if paired with a reflection or quote
- Wordmark "AUWA" bottom-centre, small

Template 4: Carousel Slide (Japanese Wisdom)

- 1080 x 1350px, void background
- Slide 1: Cormorant headline (the hook)
- Slides 2-6: Instrument Sans body text with generous spacing, one idea per slide
- Final slide: call-to-action or wordmark
- Consistent padding, font sizes, and colour across all slides

Reel Cover Image

- 1080 x 1920px (9:16), but design the central 1080 x 1350px area for feed grid crop

- Cormorant text centred in the safe zone
- Void background or atmospheric photography (muted)

Story Template

- 1080 x 1920px
- Void background
- Cormorant text for quotes/reflections
- Instrument Sans for interactive elements (polls, questions)
- AUWA wordmark top-left (small, consistent placement)

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9. Motion & Animation

Principles

- **Slow and deliberate.** AUWA doesn't rush. Animations use ease-out-expo (cubic-bezier 0.16, 1, 0.3, 1) — fast departure, gentle arrival. Like a breath out.
- **Fade, don't slide.** Elements appear by fading in and gently scaling, not sliding in from edges. The app already uses this approach (Framer Motion fade-in components).
- **The light shower is the hero animation.** All other motion is supporting — subtle, ambient, never competing.

For Social (Reels / Runway)

- Slow, atmospheric. Think 0.5-1 second transitions between elements.
- Rieko's illustrations can have subtle parallax (foreground/background layers moving at different speeds) or gentle breathing motion (Runway's motion tools)
- Text reveals: fade in word by word or line by line, Cormorant, centred, against void
- Never: fast cuts, beat-synced transitions, zoom-punch effects, or anything that feels like a TikTok trend

Audio

- Ambient, atmospheric, warm. Suno-generated tones that feel like the inside of a temple.
- No beats, no vocals, no commercial music
- The existing ambient.mp3 on the teaser page sets the reference tone

10. Across the Four Sections

All sections live under a single domain: **auwa.life** with subpaths. auwalife.com mirrors to auwa.life for the Japan market. Social handles: @auwa.life (Instagram, TikTok, YouTube), @auwa_life (X), @Auwa (LinkedIn).

/app (Kokoro Mirror)

Dark-first. Minimal chrome during the experience. Cormorant for AUWA's voice, Instrument Sans for UI. The revelation screen is the hero — everything else supports getting there and reflecting afterward.

/store (Craftsman Marketplace)

Slightly lighter touch — product pages may use light backgrounds for product photography clarity, but the overall framing and navigation stays dark. Cormorant for editorial (craftsman stories, product descriptions), Instrument Sans for functional (pricing, specs, cart). Products shot on white backgrounds (AI-standardised) sit within the dark AUWA frame. Note: Shopify integration may require headless Storefront API or subdomain proxy (store.auwa.life) to maintain the /store subpath — technical decision to make during build.

/journal (Editorial)

Dark-first. Editorial feel — more text, more space, more story. Photography-led. Cormorant-heavy for headlines, Instrument Sans for body. Long-form articles, craftsman profiles, travel essays. This is where the brand breathes most fully and where SEO value accumulates.

/book (Illustrated Stories)

Dark-first. The illustrated stories and the AUWA universe origin. Cormorant-heavy. Illustration and animation-forward. The most immersive, atmospheric section.

Shared Elements

- Same header: wordmark left, navigation right (links adapt per section)
- Same footer: minimal, wordmark, copyright, email
- Same font stack: Cormorant + Instrument Sans + Noto Sans JP

- Same colour system: void/cosmic palette + Yamato emotional states
- Same animation easing: ease-out-expo
- Single Next.js codebase serving all sections

The four sections should feel like four rooms in the same building, not four separate buildings.

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11. Brand Book — Living System

The Approach

The brand lives in three places, all staying in sync:

1. **This document** (`context/brand.md`) — The written rules. Every Claude Code session reads this and applies it. Source of truth for *decisions*.

2. **The website brand page** (`auwa.life/brand`) — A living visual style guide built as a Next.js page within the website itself. It reads from the same CSS custom properties (`globals.css`) as the production site, so it's always up to date. Shows logo, colour palette, typography specimens, type scale table, spacing system, component examples, motion values, and design principles. Shareable by URL. No separate PDF needed — send the link.

3. **Code** (`globals.css` + `@theme inline` block) — The implementation. The OKLCH colour system, font stack, spacing, and motion variables are defined once in CSS and consumed everywhere: the website, the brand page, and eventually the app. Change a variable, everything updates.

For external partners / collaborators: Share the `/brand` URL. If they need a static file, print the page to PDF from the browser. The Figma component library (social templates, app design system) remains the visual production environment — but the website brand page is the canonical reference for brand rules.

Remaining Figma Steps

- **Social content templates** — Build the 4 template types (quote, photography, illustration, carousel) as duplicatable Figma components using the locked colour system and typography
- **Photography preset** — Lightroom "AUWA — Atmospheric" preset (desaturate, warm, grain, vignette) applied to all photography content

- **Test grid** — 3x3 Instagram layout check before posting begins

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12. What This Document Is

A working reference that evolves as AUWA evolves. Not a monument. The decisions above are enough to build all four sections of auwa.life, create months of coherent Instagram content, and brief any future collaborator.

When something isn't covered here, apply two principles: **would this feel at home in the quiet room?** and **does this let the content speak, or does it compete with it?**

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